

Henri Cartier-Bresson

1908 – 2004 · "the eye of the century" · the decisive moment

ART 205 · DIGITAL PHOTOGRAPHY

PHOTOGRAPHER PRESENTATION

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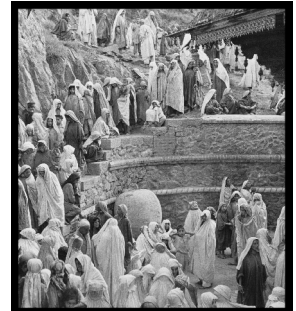
Behind the Gare Saint-Lazare, Paris, 1932



Hyères, France, 1932



Seville, Spain, 1933



Srinagar, Kashmir, 1948

LIFE IN TEN LINES

- 1908** Born near Paris, wealthy textile family ("Cartier-Bresson thread").
- 1926** Studies painting with the Cubist André Lhote — geometry, golden section; sits with Breton's Surrealists.
- 1931** Sees Munkácsi's *Three Boys at Lake Tanganyika*: "photography can fix eternity in a moment".
- 1932** Buys a Leica. Early masterpieces: Gare Saint-Lazare, Hyères, Brussels.
- 1933–35** Solo show at Julien Levy Gallery, New York; exhibits with Álvarez Bravo in Mexico City.
- 1936–39** Assistant to film director Jean Renoir.
- 1940–43** Prisoner of war, 35 months; escapes on the third attempt.
- 1947** MoMA "posthumous" show (they thought he was dead); co-founds Magnum Photos with Capa, Chim, Rodger, Vandivert.
- 1948–54** Gandhi's last hours & funeral; China, fall of the Kuomintang; 1952 *The Decisive Moment* (cover by Matisse); 1954 first Western photographer in the USSR after Stalin.
- 1970s–2004** Returns to drawing. Fondation HCB opens 2003. Dies in Provence, aged 95.

THE SIX RULES (TECHNIQUES)

- 01 One Leica, one 50 mm lens** — the eye's own angle of view; chrome covered with black tape.
- 02 No flash** — "like coming to a concert with a pistol in your hand". Available light only.
- 03 No cropping** — the black film border proves the full frame. Compose in the camera.
- 04 No darkroom** — a lab printed his work; the picture ends when the shutter closes.
- 05 Black & white** — light, line, shape, texture, tonal contrast.
- 06 Geometry first** — find the structure, then wait for life to enter it.

THREE CARTIER-BRESSONS (CHÉROUX, 2014)

1926–35 the Surrealist · 1936–46 the engaged witness · 1947–70s the Magnum eye, then the contemplative.

VOCABULARY TO LISTEN FOR

- Decisive moment** — meaning + geometry in the same instant.
- Framing** — what the edges include; a "frame within a frame".
- Shutter speed** — fast = frozen motion (the jump); slow = blur (the cyclist).
- Depth of field** — how much is sharp, front to back.
- Exposure** — how light or dark; available light only.
- Balance / symmetry** — visual weight; a reflection doubles it.
- Line & rhythm** — ladders, rails, hoops; repeated shapes.
- Form / shape / silhouette** — the jumping man as a black cut-out.
- Texture** — plaster, rubble, feathers, wool.
- Tonal contrast** — deep blacks against bright whites.
- Proportion** — small figures in big space.
- Golden section** — the painter's ratio he learned from Lhote.

ARTIST STATEMENT · THE DECISIVE MOMENT, 1952

"To me, photography is the *simultaneous recognition, in a fraction of a second, of the significance of an event as well as of a precise organization of forms which give that event its proper expression.*"

Epigraph (Cardinal de Retz, 1717): "There is nothing in this world that does not have a decisive moment."

The decisive part of Cartier-Bresson's process takes place not in the mechanism in his hand but in the vision in his head.

Lincoln Kirstein · MoMA, 1947

Photographing is nothing. Looking is everything.

HCB · Le Figaro Magazine, 1989

Very clear, simple pictures, classically organized, almost like a painting from the 17th century.

Peter Galassi · MoMA, 2010

I don't take the photograph. The photograph takes me.

HCB · Charlie Rose, 2000

Sources: Cartier-Bresson, *The Decisive Moment* (1952; Steidl 2014) · *The Mind's Eye* (Aperture 1999) · Kirstein & Newhall, MoMA 1947 · Galassi, *The Modern Century*, MoMA 2010 · Chéroux, *Here and Now*, 2014 · Assouline, *A Biography*, 2005 · Fondation HCB (henricartierbresson.org) · Magnum Photos · MoMA collection · NYT obituary (Kimmelman, 2004) · Wikipedia. Photographs © Henri Cartier-Bresson / Magnum Photos, educational use only.